Everything All at Once!

It's so hard the first day, it will feel like you are dying inside yourself and all you can do is tell yourself that it will get better the next day. But the 2nd day is even worse than the first and you can't lie to yourself because your brain will reject that excuse. So, you somehow hang on to yourself without any excuse, you will feel nothing inside of yourself, just hollow. You live without knowing what's happening to you because it's all you wanted in your entire life and just because of that reason, you stick to yourself.

AND THEN YOU SEE THROUGH.

And right now, I don't know why I'm writing this. I don't know if it's a journal or my feelings or my experience or any other stupid things, but sure it has happened to me. I always thought writing to yourself was childish and foolish and stupid because I always thought "you know these things and what's there to write", right? Anyway, I'm writing. Just you know this is not a success story or anything but of course like every person on social media is a millionaire in their twenties, I also wanted to be. Hehehe!

So, this is when I got into my first job at a corporate company and for the first time I was going to Ahmedabad or any other state ALONE. I always wanted to live alone; I liked travelling and wanted to meet big successful people every day. So, in short, I was happy when I heard the news. Accommodation facilities were arranged and I was thrilled to go.

It was 3 days of travelling to reach Ahmedabad from Kerala by train, it was a Friday when I finally departed from my home to Ahmedabad. As a guy who doesn't know any Hindi at all I knew it would be hard for a few weeks and I also didn't forget to expect the worst because I always believed in expecting the worst, so it won't worsen in reality. But nothing concerned me that much apart from the Washroom in the train, I cannot stand a non-clean place especially washrooms. But nothing bad or good happened on the train, it went smoothly!

I watched 3 films in 3 days, slept most of the time and listened to music while I enjoyed traveling. Nothing memorable had happened during those 3 days.

As a Malayali I had searched for people from Kerala prior to my travel to Ahmedabad and was successful in getting a number. I was not scared much about Hindi because I had already downloaded a translator app on my phone and was so overconfident.

It was not that hard till now, I felt good. But as you will see everything will go wrong from now on...

I reached the station and I knew the Malayali guy was busy for some days and I should go alone to the PG that I booked but again I felt no pressure. I entered an auto from the railway station and said where I wanted to go, that's when I knew my phone was on 1 percent... now it switched off.

Surprisingly enough my driver doesn't know the place I wanted to go to. And me who had downloaded the translator app to speak was speechless. After many km of driving around, after stopping many times to ask people about the address all I knew was "bhodekdev, Ahmedabad school ke pass". Somehow after many hours of driving for just 8km I finally reached the place. Now the task was to find the PG where I should be staying. After many rounds of going around the place I thought was Bhodekdev with the sentence "Bhodekdev Ahmedabad school ke pass", I smiled at everyone on the way so that one may talk to me in English or in Malayalam, even though it was a dream I just thought that. Finally, I thought of any other information that I could get from my brain and yes, I got another clue. "09-pg jolly". Yes, it was Jolly's PG that I was staying at and number 9. After exactly 45 minutes of simply roaming, I was getting tired and every non-positive thought was coming into my brain. All I wanted to do was go in there, take a good bath, and sleep. Finally, I found the place I was staying at and was happy. But! there is always a but that's waiting for you isn't it.

I entered the house that had 9 written on it. I played "charades" with the guys over there and somehow, they understood why I was there acting all strange. I understood why they all laughed at me but at this point I couldn't care less. For

heads-up nobody knew Malayalam. That was very helpful during the time they laughed. (Hehe)

Everyone entered the house with their shoes and it was a rainy day, the floor was dirty (didn't like it), but like I said I always expected the worst so it was less of a problem for me.

One Hindi guy showed me the way to my room; with so much excitement and non-expectation I walked in the direction he was pointing at. He also said something in Hindi but like I said who cares?

While walking towards the room through the stairs, lights got dimmer and dimmer and suddenly it was like night, there was no sunlight or any light for that matter that was entering into that place, there was no ventilation whatsoever. Whatever that place could be called it sure wasn't bad, it was the worst! And it by far made me question about what the fck just happened (sorry about the language (I had to use it)). I walked to my room, the more I walked the foggier I got. I had to use my flashlight. There were many people sleeping there in a row. I walked past all of them to the corner where there was a room for 3 people and in one of the beds there was no one.

That was it.

The Hindi guy pointed to the bed and said something that I couldn't care less about. It was a 3-person room (as I expected) not like I expected, there was room for 3 beds and just that. There was no ventilation, one of the persons was sleeping, another one was eating paan-like food, there was one fan which dropped hot air. I could touch the ceiling and I'm 5'4", the floor was dirty, the bed was dirty, everything I saw around could be described with the word "dirty" on it. My overconfidence was peeling off one by one from the railway station and it was all over for me at that point. But I said to myself "Shit" with water flowing from my eyes. I closed my eyes and told myself that it was a dream, this is not where I was supposed to be and if I opened my eyes, it would all go away. But nothing changed, I was hopeless, I felt the intensity of nothingness piling up more and more for the first time in my entire life. And just when you know it can't be any worse and you are living in the shittiest

room in the entire universe you realized that you need to go to the washroom. Fear in me piled up again, this time with even greater intensity, I walked towards the stairs, on the way I asked a guy "where is the washroom". After so much trying he finally understood what I was trying to say. I have to go upstairs and the washroom was outside, he said. Each step I took my heart beat faster and each thought I had in my mind was faster still. When you are at the stage where you question reality itself it's so hard to think straight. Many of you will think that all of these are less painful compared to the thing's others are facing, you are 100 percent right. But for a guy who had lived in a clean house and a guy who always wanted the surroundings to be clean, and a guy who never went to any other place alone, didn't know the language and everyone scared the shit out of me, it was for me a nightmare.

A guy pointed me in the direction of the washroom, it was outside. On the way was a flies' den. You need to battle with 1000 flies to get to the washroom, on the way there was food waste all around. I entered the washroom, there was no lock, I found myself a piece of wood, locked the washroom.

It was no different than the worst toilet that I had imagined on the way, no it was worse. Again, for the second time my eyes teared up. And that was it, I wanted to go home. There was nothing that would make me go back from my decision, yes it was decided. In less than an hour I made the final decision.

I went to the room after taking a video of the washroom so that I could tell in "veedu" (family WhatsApp group) that it's bad and I wanted to go home. Suddenly Mom called to ask about the place, I said the place is too bad I don't see myself living here, Mom passed the phone to Father. He asked me the same and I replied the same. He told me about the time he was in Qatar…... I was not at all the man for advice especially at that time. I knew the struggle he had faced in Qatar but that was not the time or the place. Suddenly he said the magic words that in that situation made some sense. "If you don't feel like living there, you should come home, it's alright" and that was the only time I wanted to stay there. Then my mom talked to me, she was emotional, I know how emotional my mom can get during these times that's the reason I will always say "everything's alright" to her no matter what, even if I'm dying.

Then messages came from my brothers:

"Always remember, Gujarat airport isn't far from there, you can come home in less than 4 hours"

There comes the second time I wanted to stay; I knew they were trying to help me with all the messages but my ego didn't want me to think about what they were trying to say. But that helped me in a way if you ask me, so I think a little ego is good.

Ok, so after I went from the washroom to the place everyone called "The room". Every time I got closer to the room my heart got heavier, my eyes teared up and I wanted to kill myself. I opened the phone and saw the news about a national disaster that had happened, I saw many children crying for their whole family, and for the first time since many hours I felt grateful for the life I had and that news kept me going from “very” bad to bad. When I think about it it's ironic that such bad news for an entire world including me made me a little better. Around 11am I was very tired and went to sleep, I remember at exactly 11:10am I woke up feeling all sweated up due to the steam that was coming from the fan, I felt difficult to breathe.

I got up and went outside to buy some things. It was 2km to the supermarket and I decided to walk.

For the first time in my entire life, I felt so small and tiny, everywhere there were huge corporate buildings, people didn't speak a word of English, I couldn't find any Malayali, I didn't know the place very well, every negative thought came to me just standing to cross the road and I couldn't for nearly 20 minutes. And after some time, I reached the market.

I collected soap with many small things for daily usage and walked straight to the PG. While walking I saw many things including people living in a tent to people going with Rolls-Royce. If I saw them living in the tent, I felt grateful for the life I was having and suddenly Range Rovers would come up for me to question "My life" and what a waste it had been.

I reached the PG and thought maybe a movie would make me feel better so I reached over to my laptop to see a movie, but this time I went to the upper living room to see the movie because it was too unbearable in the basement. My intuition was right, a movie made me forget reality. It was one of the few things that were all the same irrespective of the situation.

So instead of one I watched two and it was already time for dinner and it was some chapatis and curry, I ate that and went straight to bed underground, this time I slept very well because I had made my body very tired. Because I was aware of the fact that it was the only way I could sleep. And sleeping with full consciousness was not at all an option. And I was also aware that the next day was Sunday and I had already found the church that had Malayalam holy mass.

The next morning, I got myself to church and for the first time in many years I was so happy to go to church. But unfortunately, it wasn't a Malayalam holy mass but I did see some Malayalees there and felt good. I saw a guy; we went to eat food. It was fine that day, nothing unexpected happened that day. I watched movies and ate food and was fine. That day I slept on the couch in the living room and every day since.

The next day was my first day at work but I wasn't that excited seeing all this I expected less. But I did go for a morning jog but it was raining so I got back after half an hour. The work was alright. It was a training period and I didn't have anything to do other than sitting in the chair all day long.

I made myself a few friends at work and at the PG, they told me they would help me find a new room and were very friendly and I felt good. And as an introvert myself or as my college friends called me so, it was so hard for me to smile at everyone, everywhere hoping someone would come and talk to me and say "hi, nattil evideya."

The next few days went the same. Apart from battling with flies and mosquitoes to enter the washroom which was again full of filth, the corporate job was tiring. We had to be from 9-5:30 inside the office. Other than that, it was alright. And I had a feeling I could adjust to live here until I got a fever the very next day.

Things went wrong again. And this time it was twice as hard as the first. How, I don't know how but it was twice as hard, many times I got the phone to tell my father "I quit", but somehow, I didn't. The whole week I had a headache, body pain, back pain and more than any of that I felt worse in my mind. I didn't have the power to do anything because it was too heavy for my heart to lift my hand itself. And I had every reason for me to leave the place and go home. I had 2 jobs in my hand waiting at that point in time, I rejected all of that to live in this filth because deep down in my heart I thought I would regret the decision. Not because it was the highest paid job I had, but only because I thought so in my heart. And if you think what a non-practical thought that is? I would say, absolutely!

Everywhere I looked the room rent was high, which I couldn't afford. Everyone told me that it was difficult to find a room anywhere and that I should be living here for I didn't know how much time, maybe the whole time I work here! With the fever that had still not gone and hearing news like this I lost all my hope. Every time my family called me, I was ready and prepared to say "I'm done". But somehow, I couldn't.

Every day something would happen either it was good or it would be extremely bad, like when I was walking back to the PG after work, the road was full of water so I tried to escape from the water by going through the edge on the side but I slipped and fell down and my pants were soaked. With deep dissatisfaction with myself, with all the pain from the fever I stood for nearly 2 minutes and thought about the life I had. And like perfect timing a BMW came and soaked my shirt to make it a full cycle. I was so sure that it was neither my place nor my time to live in Ahmedabad.

After nearly 2 weeks of my life in Ahmedabad, things started to change. My fever started to go away slowly,

I was picking up some Hindi, I really laughed for the first time, I started to speak some Hindi, I started to search for rooms with my friends who knew the place and even at work too I was starting to feel comfortable.

"Life is a tragedy in close-up and comedy in long shot", and one meaning of the quote is to stay open-minded and try not to be serious all the time. I know I can't but maybe you guys can, just try it.

We ask God for our dreams and when he gives us opportunities to achieve those dreams, we don't see it. Not only that, for the same we reject God himself. What stupidity!

So, try to see through it and get all the tools that help you do the same. Everyone is different, everyone will be having their own tools to master, find them and use them. Maybe it's gym or meditation or practicing martial arts or even cooking. Whatever you do if you find true peace in it, follow that. You shouldn't be happy or excited while you're doing it but you will be at peace at the end of the day. It's a myth that if you achieve your dream, you will be happy, it is just the opposite, you will feel completely devastated, you will get hurt and you will fail, but you will have peace at the end of the day and that matters. Maybe it was the same peace that made me say "it's over". And every time my mom called me maybe it was the same peace that told me not to say "I'm scared here, I want to come home". I always knew somehow that I had to survive this, and if I don't, I would regret this. I have regretted many times in my entire life, from school to college. From not saying "I like this" to not saying "thanks" or from "I don't have time" to "maybe tomorrow". I couldn't bear another big one like that. I'm not saying from now on I will not regret anything, but from now on, if my heart says something that my brain doesn't understand or can't grasp, I am doing it.

I told you that things were starting to change, it wasn't until that day.

One day I was walking back from work and I saw "Academy of Brazilian Jiu-Jitsu". I enrolled in the academy, (same day I started to write this journal which had turned into something else (sorry for that)), I always wanted to study martial arts and when I saw the board I was really happy. When I reached the PG, the washroom was cleaned (30%), I was allowed to sleep in an AC room because one guy who lived there suddenly went home, food was good, I had a few laughs with friends. This is the same day I gave a deposit for my new single

room which was a little far away from the current PG that I would be joining from September 15th onwards. Even though it was 1 month away, there was a surety that I would be living in another place from next month onwards.

That day I slept well. A little too well.

From that day onwards I had a smile on my face, my heart felt lighter not because everything was going easy but the thought that I could handle much more than I could ever dream, it made me confident.

As a god-fearing person from a very traditional family like mine, prayer was a main part of it from my childhood to the teenage years I was exposed to praying like no other. But to go to church was boring, to say evening prayer was stupid because I would rather see a movie. But I knew the prayers and importance of it and how to pray, I just didn't. I was always a science guy to this date and always will be.

"A little science estranges you from God, but much science brings you back", and I completely agree.

Praying was one of the few things that felt the same irrespective of the place, church was the only thing I could go to and be at peace, saying the rosary was the medium to feel light in heart, talking to God was the only way to feel confident and not fear people or situations around you. It was the only thing I could do and completely forget about anything happening around you even if it meant the end of the world.

It was already the third week in Ahmedabad. I was counting days so that I could go home (yes, at the end of the month I would be going home for my brother's marriage), when I first came here, I was so sure that I would not survive here for a day but to see it's already been 3 weeks I was excited to see that the time was moving fast.

The situation was all the same, what changed was me. The room was all the same, the washroom was dirty, I was not getting enough sleep as mosquitoes were so tactical at night, in fact it was worse in case of the situation all around, but it was not affecting me anymore (70% fact). I changed (90% Fact)!

The harder the situation the more reformed you become. I suggest you do the same, do what you hate every day, I mean it. When I say all these things you think I am doing the things I'm saying. That's not the truth; the truth is I'm also trying (failing too many times). What I know is I will not quit nor should you….

Today, that day comes when I finally am going home after 1 month of experience. I have 15 days of leave, after that I shall come back. But I'm sure this time I will not feel smaller. I have few things in my mind when I get back to Ahmedabad again.

Let's see what happens now.

Don’t worry I made it 12 months there.

- **Found a new place to stay**
- **Adapted more**
- **Found some friends for games 4 times a week (game changer)**
- **Was hard? Yes, but also peaceful**
- **After 3,4 months It was nothing**
- **Finally, I resigned after 11 months happily.**

Remember wherever you are, just remembered;

This too shall pass.